

EYEWITNESS October 19, 1864

Sheridan's ride

Also known as the Battle of Belle Grove, the Battle of Cedar Creek erupted on October 19, 1864, in Virginia's Shenandoah Valley. General Philip Sheridan's ride to the battle from Winchester revived Union morale, and fighting barely lasted a day before Union troops emerged victorious. The loss was devastating for the Confederates.

"About 9 o'clock, everything looked very gloomy. General Sheridan was absent, a portion of the army much demoralized, the whole of it driven back from its chosen and fortified position on the bank of Cedar Creek. About 10 o'clock, General Sheridan arrived on the field of disaster, amid the cheers of his army, cheers more deafening than the artillery which was then engaged. The tide of battle immediately turned. Stragglers began to organize and to return to the battle. The line of battle was at once strengthened with new spirit and numbers ... the musketry was fearful and terrific, exceeding anything at the Winchester fight and reminding our veterans of Gettysburg ... the Rebel rear made but one effort to resistance, giving our heroes one volley and then fled in perfect confusion. It was now dark. Unknown, our boys entered amid the enemy and mingled in their perfectly demoralized columns ... We routed them as never a large army was routed."

LOUIS N. BEAUDRY, 5TH NEW YORK CAVALRY, FROM *THE DIARY OF A UNION CHAPLAIN COMMENCING FEBRUARY 16, 1863*

"My Dear Allie, Oh what a victory we had yesterday morning—What a defeat yesterday evening! I hardly know how to write about it to you. I am nearly dying for sleep. Just think I have slept but one hour in over sixty hours, besides undergoing the most constant & arduous labor ... oh how distressed I am. Thank the Good Being for my safety. I have another bullet as a keepsake. It struck me & lodged in my clothes ... this is my first defeat on a battlefield. I did all I could. I hurled the brigade alone against the charging Yankee line, in the evening drove them back, but they came back again, lapped me on all sides,